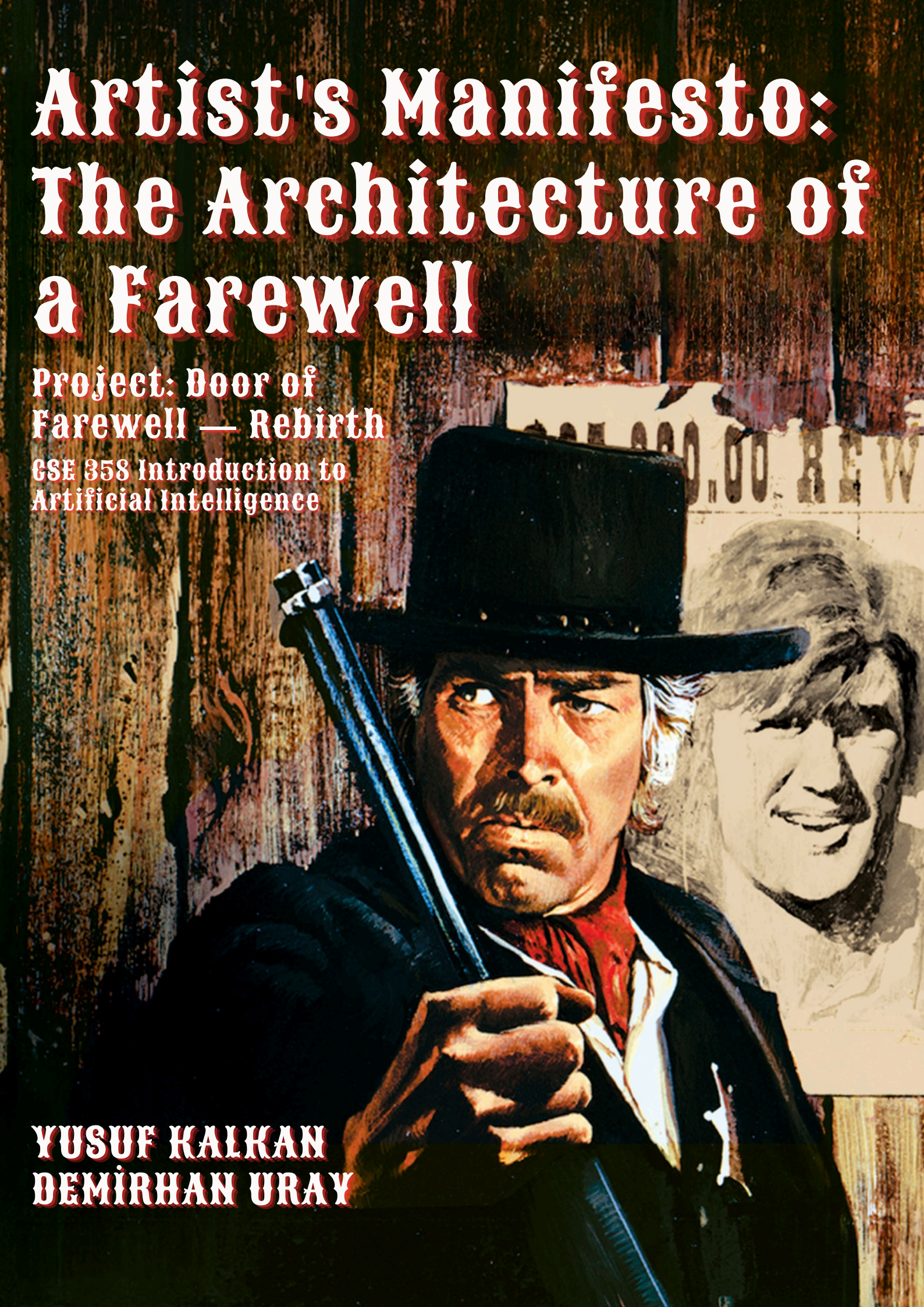


Artist's Manifesto: The Architecture of a Farewell

Project: Door of
Farewell — Rebirth

CSE 358 Introduction to
Artificial Intelligence

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I. Why This Medium? The Probability of Grief

We did not start with a concept. We started with a question that felt almost too simple: what does a song look like when you strip away everything except the math?

MIDI data reduces music to timestamps and integers. Duration, Pitch, Technique. When we first ran Dylan's file through our parser and saw the output a long list of tokens like quarter, G2, normal it felt strange. The song was gone. What remained was a skeleton.

But then we realized: this is what grief does too. It reduces everything. The person is gone, and what remains is the pattern of their absence when they used to call, what chair they sat in, which chord they always played wrong. An N-gram model learns from patterns. So does mourning.

That is why this medium. Not because it was clever, but because it felt honest.

II. What Caught Us: The Weight of 1973

1973 is easy to research. You find the summary: Vietnam, Watergate, counterculture in decline. You read it and think you understand.

You do not, until you listen to the song again.

"Mama, take this badge off of me." We spent a long time sitting with that line. It is not angry. It is not poetic. It is just exhausted. The sheriff in Peckinpah's film is dying, but the line sounds like a man who was already tired long before the wound. That specific kind of fatigue not dramatic, not noble, just worn down was everywhere in 1973. And it is the hardest emotion to fake.

So we made a decision early on: the historical weight had to be inside the math, not just mentioned in the documentation. The LLM in our pipeline does not analyze lyrics in a generic way. It is explicitly asked to evaluate them through the lens of 1973's specific exhaustion. That score becomes the alpha value. High grief, tight model. Low grief, loose model. The year 1973 is a floating-point number somewhere in our pipeline, and we think that is the most honest thing we built.

III. AI As What? The Machine as a Mirror

The assignment asks whether AI was a tool, a collaborator, or a mirror. In this project, the AI is a mirror.

We did not use generative AI to do the creative work for us. We used it to reflect the emotional logic we had already designed. An N-gram model does not feel sorrow, and an LLM does not understand the Vietnam War. They are indifferent calculators. But when we wired them together making the LLM's sentiment score constrain the N-gram's probability distribution the system started reflecting something recognizably human: the tendency to stay close to familiar things when we are grieving, and to drift toward chaos when we feel free.

The machine mourning is just numbers shifting in an array. The emotional logic driving those numbers is entirely ours.

Whether that makes the output meaningful is a question we are still not sure how to answer.

IV. Our Doors: Knocking on Different Thresholds

"Everyone knocks on heaven's door in their own way. What matters is not what you find behind it, but who you discover yourself to be while knocking."

As a team, we realized that the concept of a farewell is deeply personal. Here is what knocking on heaven's door means to each of us.

Yusuf Kalkan's Door

For me, this song is not a metaphor. It is something closer to a memory.

On February 6th, 2023, the earthquakes hit Hatay the city where I was born and raised. After the disaster, I had to leave. Not permanently, but the city was gone in a way that made the word "temporary" feel meaningless. I spent around six months somewhere else, waiting to return to a place I was not sure would still be there when I did.

Leaving Hatay in that condition was the hardest goodbye I have ever had to say. Not to a person, but to a place. Seeing the streets I grew up in completely destroyed, knowing people from my city had died, and still having to pack a bag and go somewhere safe that is what this song sounds like to me now. When Dylan sings "It's gettin' dark, too dark to see," I do not hear a metaphor. I hear a city with no lights left on.

My knock on that door was walking away from the ruins, not knowing what I would find when I came back.

Demirhan Uray's Door

For me, "Knockin' on Heaven's Door" captures a very specific kind of heartbreak: leaving your hometown right after finding the people you were meant to find there.

After almost a decade of looking for where I belonged, I finally felt like I had built something real a group of people, a sense of place. And then it was time to leave again. It was harder than any of the times before, precisely because it finally meant something.

But somewhere in the middle of trying to turn that feeling into this project, something shifted. I understood that the world behind the door was never really the point. What mattered was who I had become while standing in front of it, deciding whether to knock.

V. Team Contributions

Yusuf Kalkan: Conceptual design of the project, Gemini API integration for historical sentiment analysis, design of the emotion-to-alpha mathematical relationship, and authoring the philosophical framework of the manifesto.

Demirhan Uray: Preparation and parsing of the musical data (DPT formatting), adaptation of the core N-gram algorithm, and integration of the MIDI synthesizer.